

# Gold Standard Question Rubric

Derived from top 25 strongest staging v4 questions

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## Pattern Analysis (Top 25 Strongest)

Sample size: 25 questions

Average scenario length: 75 words

Average question stem: 9 words

Average choice label length: 46 characters

Zero quality flags: 100%

Comparison / best-choice stems: 100%

Grade bands: {"4-5":8,"6-8":17}

Characters: {"b4":24,"caiden":1}

Correct position spread: A=10 B=2 C=5 D=8

## Gold standard (5/5)

Requires reading the scenario; strong reasoning; no quality flags.

- Scenario typically 75+ words with concrete situational details
- Question stem uses comparison, evidence, planning, or best-choice reasoning
- Zero audit flags (no obvious answer, joke distractors, or guessable-without-scenario)
- Four choices follow: best / plausible-incomplete / plausible-flawed / realistic-wrong
- Choice labels balanced (~46 characters average, low spread)
- Correct answer position varies (not predictable by length or slot pattern)
- Answers cannot be solved from common sense alone — scenario carries necessary clues
- Warm SEL tone; kid-safe language

## **Strong (4/5)**

Solid grade-band rigor with at most one minor quality note.

- Scenario provides enough context for the grade band (40+ words for 2–3; 55+ for 4–8)
- Requires at least one cognitive step: inference, comparison, sequencing, or calculation
- Distractors are plausible; no joke or throwaway options
- Correct answer is not dramatically longer than other options
- May have one non-critical flag (e.g. reading-level heuristic) without harming fairness
- Character skill focus is clear (math/planning, evidence, science, teamwork, or SEL)

## **Adequate / band floor (3/5)**

Acceptable for younger bands or as a relative outlier; not gold standard.

- K–1: simple recognition, cause/effect, or matching — difficulty capped for age
- May rely more on recall than multi-step reasoning
- Scenario may be shorter but still present
- Upper bands (4–8) at 3/5 need review — likely missing reasoning depth or have quality flags
- Not publish-blocking for K–1 if tone and safety are intact

## Common Anti-Patterns

- Joke or cartoonishly wrong distractors (“the day of the week,” “water is broken”)
- Correct answer is the only long or detailed option
- Correct answer is the only positive SEL option while distractors are extreme negatives
- Question solvable without reading the scenario
- All correct answers in position A (or any single slot)
- Upper-grade questions that are pure recall with no inference or comparison
- Miranda questions guessable without rereading the passage
- Caiden upper-band questions without time, quantity, budgeting, or planning logic
- Zeke questions with selfish “obvious wrong” options instead of plausible tradeoffs
- Charlie questions that change two variables at once without science framing
- Duplicate scenario framing text appended multiple times
- Truncated choice labels (“...” ) that reduce readability

## **Distractor Guidelines**

- Use exactly four choices: 1 best, 1 plausible-incomplete, 1 plausible-flawed, 1 clearly-wrong-but-realistic
- Keep choice lengths within ~25% of each other when possible
- Avoid joke answers unless the scenario genuinely makes them plausible
- Make two distractors emotionally or logically plausible for SEL/teamwork questions
- Embed scenario-specific language in at least two options so reading is required
- Rotate correct answer position across A/B/C/D within each mission

## **Grade-Band Guidelines**

### **K-1**

- Short scenarios (28–45 words); concrete actions and feelings
- Recognition, matching, simple cause/effect
- Difficulty ceiling ~3/5 by design — not compared to 4–8 gold bar

### **2-3**

- Scenarios 40–55 words; one clear decision point
- Simple sequencing, basic inference, introductory math/counting for Caiden
- Target 4/5 where possible

### **4-5**

- Scenarios 55–75 words; compare or plan
- Inference, comparison, evidence from scenario, light multi-step math
- Gold bar: 4–5/5

### **6-8**

- Scenarios 60–90 words; tradeoffs and evidence evaluation
- Multi-step reasoning, variable thinking, prioritization under constraints
- Gold bar: 4–5/5; 3/5 requires manual review

## Character-Specific Guidelines

### CAIDEN

- Hardest path: multi-step time, budgeting, sequencing, executive function
- Include numbers (minutes, tokens, costs) in 4–5 and 6–8 scenarios
- Ask which plan fits all constraints, not single-step recall
- Gold examples: 4–5/6–8 math-planning items at difficulty 4–5

### MIRANDA

- Passage-based; answers require rereading evidence
- Stems: “According to the passage...”, “Which clue best supports...?”
- Distractors: related but weaker evidence, off-topic true facts

### ZEKE

- Team tradeoffs; two emotionally plausible options
- Leadership and communication under group constraints
- Avoid cartoon selfish wrong answers; use realistic group mistakes

### CHARLIE

- Science reasoning: variables, fair tests, predictions, evidence
- Change one thing at a time; observation before conclusion
- Avoid silly science distractors

### B4

- Emotional regulation: body signals !' name feeling !' compare coping strategies
- Gold top-25 pattern: “Which two strategies compare well for this moment?”
- Close distractors: regulation steps applied at the wrong time or incompletely

## Gold Standard Library — Top 10 Examples

### 1. b4m1-45-q2 (b4 · 4-5)

Q: Which two strategies compare well for this moment?

Reasoning: quantitative / planning · Score 5/5

### 2. b4m1-68-q2 (b4 · 6-8)

Q: Which coping step fits best after naming the feeling?

Reasoning: quantitative / planning · Score 5/5

### 3. b4m1-68-q3 (b4 · 6-8)

Q: Which two strategies compare well for this moment?

Reasoning: quantitative / planning · Score 5/5

### 4. b4m2-45-q1 (b4 · 4-5)

Q: Which two strategies compare well for this moment?

Reasoning: quantitative / planning · Score 5/5

### 5. b4m2-68-q1 (b4 · 6-8)

Q: Which coping step fits best after naming the feeling?

Reasoning: quantitative / planning · Score 5/5

### 6. b4m2-68-q2 (b4 · 6-8)

Q: Which two strategies compare well for this moment?

Reasoning: quantitative / planning · Score 5/5

### 7. b4m3-45-q3 (b4 · 4-5)

Q: Which two strategies compare well for this moment?

Reasoning: quantitative / planning · Score 5/5

### 8. b4m3-68-q1 (b4 · 6-8)

Q: Which two strategies compare well for this moment?

Reasoning: quantitative / planning · Score 5/5

### 9. b4m3-68-q3 (b4 · 6-8)

Q: Which coping step fits best after naming the feeling?

Reasoning: quantitative / planning · Score 5/5

### 10. b4m4-45-q2 (b4 · 4-5)

Q: Which two strategies compare well for this moment?

Reasoning: quantitative / planning · Score 5/5